saturnCFD v1

MPI and GPU finite-volume CFD with validated methodology

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Outline

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What saturnCFD is

Goal

A single finite-volume code for scalar transport and incompressible flow, portable across CPU and GPU, parallel through MPI, driven entirely by YAML, and verified before it is trusted.

- Structured hexahedral mesh imported from Gmsh `.msh`.
- 3D from the start; a one-cell-thick mesh is treated as 2D.
- Solvers: Burgers, heat/convection–diffusion, Stokes, incompressible Navier–Stokes.
- Kokkos for CPU/GPU; MPI for distributed memory.
- Every numerical choice is documented, cited and tested.

v0 is preserved on `v0-archive`. v1 is a deliberate rewrite, not a patch on the old AMR container.

Why this order?

1. Burgers: nonlinear convection, shocks, limiters, diffusion.
2. Heat: scalar transport, Péclet effects, boundary layers.
3. Stokes: vector elliptic operator, pressure coupling, linear solver.
4. Incompressible Navier–Stokes: all of the above together.

Idea

Each PDE tests one more ingredient. A failure is localised before the next solver is added.

Compressible flow, AMR and two-phase flow are later milestones.

Implemented substrate

- Gmsh 2.2 reader; structured-hex classification and `checkMesh` report.
- Default `.vtu` + `.json`; optional `-writeVTK` patches and `.pvd`.
- yaml-cpp configuration with a typed schema and generated templates.
- SI-only validation: non-SI input is rejected, not converted.
- Single-dash CLI with help topics and shell completion.
- MPI Cartesian partition and 26-neighbour halo exchange.
- Kokkos `CellField`, device pack/unpack halo, Cartesian Laplacian.
- Periodic 2D/3D manufactured Laplacian at order 2 on 1/2/4 ranks.
- 19 CTest cases, regression tests, Doxygen HTML/PDF.

Status

The mesh/config/comm slice and the first Kokkos FVM slice are working. General `LocalMesh`, the remaining operators and PETSc are next.

Architecture

Layer	Responsibility
`core`	types, SI units, errors, timer
`config`	yaml-cpp, schema, validation, templates
`mesh`	Gmsh, `checkMesh`, structured view, VTK
`comm`	partition, ghost ownership, halo exchange
`fv`	fields, gradient, divergence, Laplacian, fluxes
`linalg`	MPI PETSc systems
`simulation`	solver registry, time loop, diagnostics
`solvers`	Burgers, heat, Stokes, incompressible

A solver owns its equations. It does not own the mesh, the halo, the YAML parser or the linear algebra.

Structured mesh and `checkMesh`

- Gmsh 2.2 ASCII: points, hexahedra, boundary physical groups.
- Classifier walks the cell dual graph and assigns a contiguous (i, j, k).
- Rejects tetrahedra, non-manifold faces, negative volumes and non-contiguous hex meshes.
- Reports counts, patches, volume/area ranges, non-orthogonality, skewness, aspect ratio, structured flag and dimension.

2D rule

A one-cell-thick 3D mesh with `empty` patches is 2D. One internal representation, one solver path.

Gmsh [3]; OpenFOAM's `checkMesh` convention is a methodology reference.

YAML and SI units

```
solver: common
units:
  system: SI
mesh:
  file: channel.msh
time:
  end: 1.0
  cfl: 0.4
```

- yaml-cpp parses; the schema validates.
- Unknown keys are errors.
- `-dumpConfig` generates the template from the same registration the solver reads.
- `-checkConfig` runs all validation before allocation.

SI only in v1

`units.system: SI` or no block is accepted. `CGS`, `length: mm`, etc. are hard errors. A future units layer converts at the configuration boundary, never in a kernel.

MPI decomposition

global grid	$n_x \times n_y \times n_z$
process grid	$p_x \times p_y \times p_z$
local block	$[i_0, i_1] \times [j_0, j_1] \times [k_0, k_1]$

- `MPI_Dims_create` chooses the process grid; `MPI_Cart_create` handles periodicity.
- 2D uses $p_z = 1$; 1D uses $p_y = p_z = 1$.
- Remainders are distributed one cell at a time from the low index.
- No METIS: a structured mesh does not need a graph partition.

Why Cartesian blocks?

Deterministic neighbours, compact messages and a direct cell $\leftrightarrow$ rank mapping.

No shared cells: owner and ghost

- Every global cell has **one owner rank**.
- Only the owner writes the valid value.
- The neighbour keeps a **read-only ghost copy**.
- Two ghost layers support MUSCL/TVD.
- 26-neighbour exchange: faces, edges, corners.

Shared face, not shared cell

Both ranks compute the same face flux from the same valid/ghost pair. Each rank updates only its own cell. No double counting.

Halo order: local periodic copies → packed MPI → physical boundary conditions.

CPU and GPU execution

- Kokkos selects the backend at **build** time: Serial/OpenMP or CUDA/HIP.
- CPU and GPU are separate build directories: `build-cpu` and `build-gpu`.
- `mpirun` launches MPI ranks; the compiled backend decides whether a rank uses a CPU or a GPU.
- Performance model: **one rank per GPU**.
- One GPU: `mpirun -np 1`. Four GPUs: `mpirun -np 4`.
- Halo first implementation: device pack $\rightarrow$ host MPI $\rightarrow$ device unpack.

Case files are hardware-independent

CPU/GPU is not in `case.yaml`. Physics stays portable.

Collocated cell-centred FVM

- Velocity and pressure at cell centroids.
- Face fluxes reconstructed from the two adjacent cells.
- Rhie–Chow correction suppresses checkerboard pressure.
- SIMPLE for steady Stokes/incompressible flow.
- PISO for transient incompressible flow.

Why not MAC?

Staggered MAC gives exact discrete continuity, but it splits the velocity components onto different meshes and fights the vector form, `.msh` import and the 2D/3D rule. Collocated FV matches OpenFOAM and the default Basilisk/Nektar++ approach [11, 1].

Governing equations

$$\text{Burgers:} \quad \frac{\partial u}{\partial t} + \nabla \cdot (u\mathbf{a}) = \nu \nabla^2 u + s$$

$$\text{Heat:} \quad \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \nabla \cdot (\mathbf{u} T) = \nabla \cdot (\alpha \nabla T) + S$$

$$\text{Stokes:} \quad -\nabla p + \mu \nabla^2 \mathbf{u} = \mathbf{f}, \qquad \nabla \cdot \mathbf{u} = 0$$

$$\text{Incompressible NS:} \quad \frac{\partial \mathbf{u}}{\partial t} + \nabla \cdot (\mathbf{u} \otimes \mathbf{u}) = -\frac{1}{\rho} \nabla p + \nu \nabla^2 \mathbf{u} + \frac{\mathbf{f}}{\rho},$$
$$\nabla \cdot \mathbf{u} = 0$$

Projection/pressure correction from Chorin [2]; SIMPLE/PISO from Patankar [7] and Issa [5]; Rhie–Chow [8].

Vector form and linear algebra

Discrete momentum

$$\mathbf{M}\frac{d\mathbf{u}}{dt} + \mathbf{C}(\mathbf{u})\mathbf{u} = -\mathbf{G}p + \mathbf{D}\mathbf{u} + \mathbf{f}$$

- One vector unknown per cell: u, v, w.
- One sparsity pattern; block size 3 or three right-hand sides.
- PETSc: `Mat`, `Vec`, `KSP`, `PC`.
- Pressure Poisson: CG + GAMG/HYPRE; Neumann null space handled explicitly.
- No home-grown Krylov solver.

Manufactured solutions: why

Question MMS answers

Does the assembled discrete operator converge to the PDE at the expected order?

- Unit tests check one function; regression checks one accepted result.
- MMS checks the full operator, including faces, ghosts, BCs, geometry and partition boundaries.
- It catches sign/coefficient errors, missed faces and halo bugs that are invisible on one rank.

Salari & Knupp [10]; Roache [9]; Oberkampf & Roy [6].

Manufactured solutions: method

Choose a smooth ϕ, substitute into the PDE, and use the residual as the source:

$$s = \mathcal{L}(\phi).$$

For the periodic Laplacian:

$$\phi = \sin(2\pi x)\sin(2\pi y)\sin(2\pi z), \qquad s = -3(2\pi)^2\phi.$$

Refine h and compute

$$p \approx \frac{\log(e_{\text{coarse}}/e_{\text{fine}})}{\log 2}.$$

Expected orders

Central Laplacian/interpolation: 2. Upwind: 1. TVD on a smooth non-extremum: about 2, with local reduction at extrema.

Measured on 1, 2 and 4 ranks

3D observed order 1.978 and 1.994; 2D 1.994 and 1.999. The 32^3 reference $L^2 = 0.1343558076$ is stored for GPU parity.

Validation roadmap

Solver	First validation	Reference
Burgers	viscous traveling wave	exact Cole–Hopf solution
Burgers	inviscid shock	characteristics/conservation
Heat	1D boundary layer	exact solution
Heat	2D/3D MMS	manufactured order
Stokes	Poiseuille/Couette	exact parabolic/linear
Stokes	cavity $Re \to 0$	converged reference
Incompressible	cavity $Re = 100, 1000$	Ghia et al. [4]
Incompressible	Taylor–Green	energy decay/order

Rule

MMS and analytic tests before a physical benchmark. Observations are recorded, including failures and order reduction.

Build and run

```
# CPU build
cmake --preset cpu
cmake --build --preset cpu -j
cmake --install build-cpu \
  --prefix "$HOME/.local"

# GPU build (installed Kokkos)
export KOKKOS_ROOT=/path/to/kokkos
cmake --preset gpu
cmake --build --preset gpu -j
cmake --install build-gpu \
  --prefix "$HOME/.local"
```

```
# one installed command
mpirun -np 4 saturnCFD case.yaml
mpirun -np 1 saturnCFD case.yaml

# tests
ctest --preset regression
ctest --preset mpi
ctest --preset fv
ctest --preset gpu
```

The installed binary carries the backend it was compiled with. CPU and GPU are separate build directories; install the one you want to run. The `cpu` preset builds `build-cpu` with Kokkos OpenMP. The `gpu` preset builds `build-gpu` and needs an installed CUDA-enabled Kokkos in `KOKKOS_ROOT`.

Help, clean and completion

```
saturnCFD -help
saturnCFD -help build
saturnCFD -help gpu
saturnCFD -help mpi
saturnCFD -help test
saturnCFD -help clean

source <(saturnCFD -completion bash)

cmake --build build-cpu --target clean
rm -rf build-cpu build-gpu
```

No memorisation

Test labels: `ctest --list-presets`. CLI: `saturnCFD -help`. Build: `-help build`. Clean: `-help clean`.

Current test status

Suite	Result
CTest total	19/19 passing
MPI distribution & halo	1, 2, 4 ranks passing
Kokkos field + halo	2 ghosts, 26 directions, 1/2/4 ranks
MMS Laplacian	order 2 in 2D/3D, 1/2/4 ranks
Mesh `checkMesh`	pass/reject fixtures passing
Config SI-only	accept/reject fixtures passing
CLI regression	help, outputs, completion, templates
Doxygen	HTML and PDF build

What is not yet tested

General `LocalMesh`, gradient/divergence, Dirichlet/Neumann MMS, advection–diffusion MMS, CUDA execution (no toolkit on this PC) and multi-GPU scaling. These are the next gates.

Status and next steps

Done

- Mesh + `checkMesh`
- YAML schema + SI validation
- CLI/help/completion/install
- MPI partition + 26-neighbour halo
- Kokkos field + device halo
- Cartesian Laplacian + periodic MMS
- 1/2/4-rank tests
- Doxygen HTML/PDF

Next

- General `LocalMesh` geometry
- gradient/divergence/interpolation
- Dirichlet/Neumann BC ghosts
- advection–diffusion MMS
- CUDA build verification
- Burgers physics and PETSc

Longer term

Stokes and incompressible NS; multi-GPU cluster scaling; AMR then two-phase flow; compressible flow.

Take-away

What makes this code trustworthy

1. A structured, validated mesh and a strict YAML/SI boundary.
2. An ownership model with no shared cells and a tested halo.
3. A single source for CPU/GPU through Kokkos, not two codes.
4. Verification by manufactured solutions before benchmarks.
5. A CLI and test layout that a user can discover, not memorise.

Questions and discussion

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